



MYANMAR

Capital city: Nay Pyi Taw
Area: 261,969 sq miles (678,500 sq km)
Population: 49,500,000
Official language: Burmese
Major religions: Buddhist 87%, Christian 6%, Muslim 4%, Hindu 1%, other 2%
Government: Military government
Currency: Kyat
Adult literacy rate: 85%
Life expectancy: 57 years
People per doctor: 3,241
Televisions: 7 per 1,000 people

MYANMAR

OVERSHADOWED BY THE POWERFUL neighboring countries of India, China, and Thailand, Myanmar (also known as Burma) is little known to the outside world. When the country became independent in 1948, it adopted a policy of political and economic isolation that reduced this once rich nation to one of the poorest on Earth. Revolts by the hill peoples and, in recent years, political repression by a military government have kept nearly all foreign influences away. Yet Myanmar is rich in natural resources, is well watered by the great Irrawaddy River, and is fertile enough to support intensive farming.

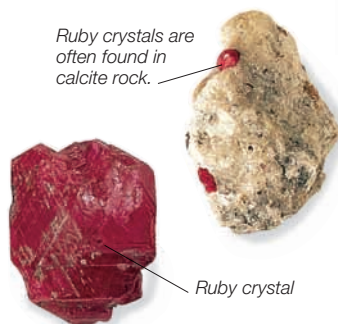


TEAK

Hard, easily carved, and containing an oil that resists water and stops iron from rusting, teak is a highly desirable wood for furniture, flooring, and other building uses. About 70 percent of the world's teak trees grow on the hills of Myanmar, but intensive felling means that soon few trees will be left standing unless action is taken to replant the forests.

NATURAL WEALTH

Rubies and sapphires are among the many gemstones produced in northern Myanmar. Many people consider these rubies to be the finest in the world because of their deep red color. Myanmar is also rich in silver, copper, jade, lead, zinc, and tin, and has extensive reserves of oil and natural gas.



Ruby crystals are often found in calcite rock.

Ruby crystal



Rubies
Poppy-growing area

THE GOLDEN TRIANGLE

The area where Myanmar, Thailand, and Laos meet is known as the Golden Triangle. Here the hill peoples grow opium poppies as one of their few sources of income. Opium is a useful painkiller, but it can also be used to make narcotics. Two-thirds of the world's heroin comes from this region. In order to combat this lethal trade, the government is encouraging the local people to plant other crops for export, such as tobacco or flowers.

The Akha people value silver highly. This chief and his family wear silver neck rings, bracelets, and ornaments on their clothes to show their wealth and status.



THE HILL PEOPLES

In the upland areas of the east, north, and west of Myanmar live the hill peoples. They include the Shan, Akha, Karen, and Kachin tribes, and make up more than a quarter of the total population. Most hill peoples live in small villages and make their living from slash-and-burn farming on the land around their villages. They are fiercely independent and resent interference from outside. As a result, more than 200,000 Karen and others have lost their lives fighting the Myanmar government for independence.

The opium poppy has white, pink, or purple flowers and can grow to a height of 4 ft (1.2 m).



Opium is made from the sap that oozes out of cuts scored in the seed head.

RANGOON

Situated in the delta of the great Irrawaddy River, the former capital city of Myanmar was established in 1852 by the British, who laid out the streets in a grid pattern. Since then, Rangoon has grown to be the country's major port and industrial center. Dominating the city is a Buddhist temple called the Shwe Dagon Pagoda. Situated on a hill just north of the city center, the gold-covered pagoda towers 325 ft (99 m) above the city streets.



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